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COMPARE AND CONTRAST: ALGORITHMIC MUSIC VS HUMAN-COMPOSED MUSIC

The advent of AI has introduced a new player in the game of music creation: Machine Learning. This essay aims to compare and constrast algorithm made music with a human creations. I will discuss three aspects: the creative processes, aesthetic qualities, and their implications on originality and cultural relevance.

Algorithmic Music is data-driven, the process is algorithms analysing vast datasets of music to generate "new" compositions (more on this later). These systems can identify patterns and structures in existing music and create new music that reflects those learned styles and genres. Human creativity, however, does not rely solely on existing data but is influenced by a myriad of factors including personal experience, cultural background, and emotional state. The human composer engages in a more intuitive and less predictable creative process.

While algorithmic compositions can achieve technical perfection, they may lack the 'human touch' that often characterizes the nuances of human-composed music. The output is often a reflection of the dataset the algorithm has been trained on, for example if I train an algorithm on Carti's music, it won't ever generate bollywood style music.

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Human composers can imbue their music with a unique signature, a reflection of their personal style and emotional depth. This music often carries the weight of the human experience.

The originality of algorithmic music is a complex issue, akin to the Ship Of Theseus problem. If a piece of music is algorithmically generated, drawing from a database of existing music, it can be argued that, like the ship that has had all of it's parts replaced overtime, the music retains its identity as a piece of art despite all its parts - the notes, rhythms and harmonies - being derived from prior works. However some would argue that the Ship of Theseus is no longer the original once all its parts have been replaced because it is does not originate from a new, singular creative act. In contrast, human-composed music is often valued for its unique creator's imprint, personal touch, and cultural context, making it distinct and reflective of the composer's individuality, despite influences from past works.

In essence, originality in music, whether algorithmic or human composed, intertwines with the creative process and aesthetic qualities to form a unique artistic identity, challenging our perception of creativity and the value of art.